Jeremiah 43 - 45

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

Tonight we watch a people walk out of the only land God ever promised them, and take the prophet with them.

A sermon finished, and the first word spoken back to it is “You speak falsely.”

A scribe blamed for the message he only wrote down.

Stones pressed into wet mortar at the gate of Pharaoh’s house, marking the spot where a throne will one day stand.

A congregation answering a prophet out loud - the only time in Scripture it happens - and the answer is no.

Cakes shaped for the queen of the sky, and a theology built entirely out of the years that happened to go well.

And then, at the very end, five quiet verses for one exhausted man who never asked to be famous.

Jeremiah 43 is the moment the remnant leaves the land under its own power.

Jeremiah 44 is the last recorded sermon of Jeremiah’s life, and the congregation refuses it to his face.

Jeremiah 45 is a letter to Baruch, filed twenty years out of order, because the God who was breaking down a nation had not stopped noticing one tired secretary.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

CHAPTER 43 - Down to Egypt, and a Throne in the Clay

Key Notes

- Verse 1 is careful to say Jeremiah delivered everything - “all the words… even all these words” - so what follows is a rejection of the complete message, not a misunderstanding of part of it (Jeremiah 43:1).
- The reply is immediate and personal: “You speak falsely. Yahweh our God has not sent you.” They do not argue with the content; they deny the commission (Jeremiah 43:2).
- The speakers are called “the proud men” - the narrator’s one editorial word in the whole scene, and it explains everything else in it (Jeremiah 43:2).
- Baruch is accused of manipulating Jeremiah. It is easier to attack the secretary than the oracle, and a scribe makes a safer target than a prophet (Jeremiah 43:3).
- Their charge inverts the actual message. Jeremiah said staying would save them; they claim he is trying to get them killed (Jeremiah 43:3).
- The disobedience is comprehensive - captains, Johanan, and all the people, from the ones who swore the oath in chapter 42 to the ones who only followed (Jeremiah 43:4).
- Verse 5 is the cruelest sentence in the chapter: the people carried out of Judah are the very ones who had just come home to it from Moab, Ammon, and Edom (Jeremiah 43:5).
- The passenger list includes the king’s daughters, and Jeremiah and Baruch - the prophet is taken into Egypt as cargo, against the word he had just preached (Jeremiah 43:6).
- Tahpanhes is a frontier garrison in the eastern Delta, the first Egyptian town on the road from Judah - they stop at the border and settle (Jeremiah 43:7).
- The word of Yahweh comes to Jeremiah in Egypt. Leaving the land did not put them outside His jurisdiction or His speech (Jeremiah 43:8).
- The sign-act is public and physical: great stones worked into the mortar of the brick pavement at the entry of Pharaoh’s house, in front of witnesses (Jeremiah 43:9).
- Nebuchadnezzar is called “my servant” for the third time in this book - the emperor is an instrument, not an author (Jeremiah 43:10).
- Egypt is put on “as a shepherd puts on his garment” - a picture of complete ease, and of a man delousing a cloak before he wears it (Jeremiah 43:12).
- Beth Shemesh here is Heliopolis, the city of the sun; its obelisks are the pillars that get broken (Jeremiah 43:13).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
“You Speak Falsely”	Jeremiah 43:2 • Jeremiah 5:12 • Isaiah 30:10
Blaming the Scribe	Jeremiah 43:3 • Jeremiah 36:4 • Jeremiah 36:26

Topic	References
Refusing to Obey Yahweh's Voice	Jeremiah 43:4 • Jeremiah 7:23-24 • Zechariah 7:11-12
Carried Back Out of the Land	Jeremiah 43:5-6 • Jeremiah 40:11-12 • Deuteronomy 28:68
The Word Reaches Him in Egypt	Jeremiah 43:8 • Psalm 139:7-10 • Ezekiel 1:1-3
Stones Hidden Under Pharaoh's Pavement	Jeremiah 43:9 • Jeremiah 13:1-7 • Jeremiah 51:63-64
"Nebuchadnezzar My Servant"	Jeremiah 43:10 • Jeremiah 25:9 • Jeremiah 27:6
Judgment on the Gods of Egypt	Jeremiah 43:12-13 • Exodus 12:12 • Isaiah 19:1

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
A True Messenger Called a Liar	Jeremiah 43:2 • John 8:45-46 • Isaiah 53:1
Going Down Into Egypt Again	Jeremiah 43:7 • Hosea 11:1 • Matthew 2:14-15
Carried Along With the People He Warned	Jeremiah 43:6 • Isaiah 53:12 • Hebrews 13:12-13
A Throne Set Where an Empire Felt Safe	Jeremiah 43:10 • Daniel 2:44 • Revelation 11:15
Every Idol Burned, One Name Standing	Jeremiah 43:12 • Isaiah 2:18-19 • Philippians 2:9-11
The Pillars of the Sun City Broken	Jeremiah 43:13 • Malachi 4:2 • John 8:12

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - Jeremiah 43 Commentary (David Guzik) - the rejection of the Egypt oracle, the forced migration, and the stones at Tahpanhes
- United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 43 - the flight to Egypt and Nebuchadnezzar's later Egyptian campaign in historical setting
- Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 43 - exposition of the sign-act at Pharaoh's entry and what it declared about Babylon's reach

Jeremiah 43 - Opening Intro

Ten days of waiting, an oath sworn before God, and an answer so tender it made the God of Israel sound like He regretted the whole discipline - and this is the reply. "You speak falsely."

Watch what they do with the accusation, because it is one of the oldest moves there is. They cannot dispute the message, so they attack the commission: Yahweh did not send you. And when that is not quite enough, they go after Baruch. The scribe did this. Somebody got to the prophet. There is always a

Baruch when people want to disobey a word without calling it the word of God - a handler, an agenda, an influence that explains the message away.

And notice the shape of the charge in verse 3: he wants to hand us over to the Chaldeans to be killed. That is the precise reverse of what Jeremiah said. He said stay and live. They heard stay and die. Fear does not merely resist a word; it rewrites it, and then argues with the version it wrote.

Then verse 5, which is the sentence to sit with. The people Johanan takes into Egypt are described as "all the remnant of Judah, who had returned from all the nations where they had been driven, to live in the land of Judah." These are the ones who came home. They heard there was a governor and a harvest, and they walked back from Moab and Ammon and Edom to be in the land again. Now they are marched out of it by their own leadership. The return is undone by the people who survived to enjoy it.

Jeremiah goes with them. He does not go willingly and he does not go silently, but he goes - an old man who has been right about everything for forty years and has never once been obeyed, taken across a border he preached against. And the first thing that happens on the other side is that God speaks to him again. That is the mercy hidden in this chapter: disobedience changed the address, not the relationship.

So he takes stones and works them into the wet mortar of the brick pavement at Pharaoh's door, where everyone can watch him do it, and says: a throne is coming here. You ran to the safest square in the strongest empire on earth, and the man you were running from will pitch his canopy directly over the spot where you are standing. Egypt will be picked up and worn like a shepherd shrugging on his coat.

Before we read, hold this next to your own fears. They did not choose Egypt because they loved Egypt. They chose it because it looked safe. The word of God is not a threat to the place we run to - it is the only accurate map of it.

Jeremiah 43:1-13 (WEB)

1 When Jeremiah had finished speaking to all the people all the words of Yahweh their God, with which Yahweh their God had sent him to them, even all these words,

2 then Azariah the son of Hoshaiah, Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the proud men spoke, saying to Jeremiah, "You speak falsely. Yahweh our God has not sent you to say, 'You shall not go into Egypt to live there;'[1,2]

3 but Baruch the son of Neriah has turned you against us, to deliver us into the hand of the Chaldeans, that they may put us to death, and carry us away captive to Babylon."[3]

---

[1] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 5:12 • Isaiah 30:10 - *they have denied Yahweh and said, it is not He - and, speak to us smooth things*

[2] **Messianic Connection:** John 8:45-46 • Isaiah 53:1 - *because I tell the truth you don't believe me, and who has believed our report*

[3] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 36:4 • Jeremiah 36:26 - *Baruch writing at Jeremiah's mouth, and a king who wanted them both arrested*

4 So Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the captains of the forces, and all the people, didn't obey Yahweh's voice, to dwell in the land of Judah.[4]

5 But Johanan the son of Kareah, and all the captains of the forces, took all the remnant of Judah, who had returned from all the nations where they had been driven, to live in the land of Judah;[5]

6 the men, and the women, and the children, and the king's daughters, and every person who Nebuzaradan the captain of the guard had left with Gedaliah the son of Ahikam, the son of Shaphan; and Jeremiah the prophet, and Baruch the son of Neriah;[6]

7 and they came into the land of Egypt; for they didn't obey Yahweh's voice: and they came to Tahpanhes.

8 Then Yahweh's word came to Jeremiah in Tahpanhes, saying,[7]

9 "Take great stones in your hand, and hide them in mortar in the brick work, which is at the entry of Pharaoh's house in Tahpanhes, in the sight of the men of Judah;[8]

10 and tell them, Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: 'Behold, I will send and take Nebuchadnezzar the king of Babylon, my servant, and will set his throne on these stones that I have hidden; and he will spread his royal pavilion over them.[9,10]

11 He will come, and will strike the land of Egypt; such as are for death will be put to death, and such as are for captivity to captivity, and such as are for the sword to the sword.

12 I will kindle a fire in the houses of the gods of Egypt. He will burn them, and carry them away captive. He will array himself with the land of Egypt, as a shepherd puts on his garment; and he will go out from there in peace.[11]

13 He will also break the pillars of Beth Shemesh, that is in the land of Egypt; and he will burn the houses of the gods of Egypt with fire.'"[12]

---

[4] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 7:23-24 • Zechariah 7:11-12 - *obey my voice - and they walked in their own counsel, and made their hearts adamant*

[5] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 40:11-12 • Deuteronomy 28:68 - *the scattered who came home to the harvest, and the curse of being brought to Egypt again*

[6] **Messianic Connection:** Isaiah 53:12 • Hebrews 13:12-13 - *numbered with the transgressors, and going outside the camp bearing His reproach*

[7] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 139:7-10 • Ezekiel 1:1-3 - *where can I go from your Spirit - and the word of Yahweh coming to a prophet in exile*

[8] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 13:1-7 • Jeremiah 51:63-64 - *the ruined sash and the stone-weighted scroll - prophecy done with the hands*

[9] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 25:9 • Jeremiah 27:6 - *Nebuchadnezzar named my servant twice before - a tool in a hand, not a power of his own*

[10] **Messianic Connection:** Daniel 2:44 • Revelation 11:15 - *a stone kingdom outlasting every throne set on stones*

[11] **Cross-Reference:** Exodus 12:12 • Isaiah 19:1 - *against all the gods of Egypt I will execute judgment, and the idols trembling at His coming*

CHAPTER 44 - The Queen of the Sky, and Whose Word Will Stand

Key Notes

- The Jews are now at Migdol, Tahpanhes, Memphis, and Pathros - the whole length of Egypt from the Delta to the south. A temporary refuge has become a diaspora (Jeremiah 44:1).
- God argues from evidence they can see with their own eyes: look at Jerusalem, look at the cities of Judah, they are a desolation today (Jeremiah 44:2).
- The cause is named without hedging - incense burned to other gods, by people who did not even know the gods they were serving (Jeremiah 44:3).
- "Rising up early and sending them" is the recurring picture of Yahweh in this book: not a distant judge but someone who gets up early to plead (Jeremiah 44:4).
- Verse 7 reframes idolatry entirely - it is "great evil against your own souls." The first casualty of the sin is the sinner (Jeremiah 44:7).
- The catalogue in verse 9 is unsparing and even-handed: the fathers, the kings, the kings' wives, your own, and your wives (Jeremiah 44:9).
- "They are not humbled even to this day" - after the siege, the famine, the burning of the temple, and the deportation, nothing has landed (Jeremiah 44:10).
- Even the harshest oracle keeps a clause open: none will return "except those who will escape," and verse 28 confirms a few will (Jeremiah 44:14).
- Verse 15 begins the only recorded instance in Scripture of a whole congregation answering a prophet out loud - and the answer is "we will not listen to you" (Jeremiah 44:15-16).
- The queen of the sky is the Ishtar-Astarte cult, served with poured drink offerings and cakes pressed into her image - domestic worship, run out of the kitchen (Jeremiah 44:17-19).
- Their argument is empirical and exactly inverted: we prospered while we served her, and we have starved since we stopped (Jeremiah 44:17-18).
- They have confused the timing. The famine came after Josiah's reform because of generations of guilt already accrued, not because the reform offended a goddess (Jeremiah 44:18).
- The women's question in verse 19 is sharp and fair: did we do any of this without our husbands? The men had signed off on all of it (Jeremiah 44:19).
- "Yahweh could no longer bear it" gives the limit in the plainest possible terms - patience that had a capacity, and reached it (Jeremiah 44:22).
- "Establish then your vows, and perform your vows" is the most chilling sentence in the chapter: God stops arguing and hands them over to what they insisted on (Jeremiah 44:25).
- The sentence in verse 26 is unique in Scripture - His name will no longer be spoken in the mouth of any man of Judah in Egypt. Not judgment by fire, but by silence (Jeremiah 44:26).

---

[12] **Messianic Connection:** Malachi 4:2 • John 8:12 - *the pillars of the sun city broken, and the Sun of Righteousness rising with healing*

- “I watch over them for evil, and not for good” turns the watching almond branch of chapter 1 around and points it at them (Jeremiah 44:27).
- Verse 28 reduces the entire forty-year contest to a single question: “whose word will stand, mine or theirs” (Jeremiah 44:28).
- The sign given is checkable and dated - Pharaoh Hophra handed to his enemies, which happened within about fifteen years (Jeremiah 44:30).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
Judah Scattered Through All of Egypt	Jeremiah 44:1 • Jeremiah 24:8 • Isaiah 11:11
“Rising Up Early and Sending”	Jeremiah 44:4 • Jeremiah 7:25 • 2 Chronicles 36:15-16
Evil Against Their Own Souls	Jeremiah 44:7 • Jeremiah 7:19 • Proverbs 8:36
“We Will Not Listen to You”	Jeremiah 44:16 • Jeremiah 6:16-17 • Isaiah 30:9
The Queen of the Sky	Jeremiah 44:17 • Jeremiah 7:18 • 2 Kings 23:5
Prosperity Credited to an Idol	Jeremiah 44:17-18 • Hosea 2:5-8 • Deuteronomy 8:17-18
Vows Performed to Another God	Jeremiah 44:25 • Numbers 30:2 • Ecclesiastes 5:4-5
Whose Word Will Stand	Jeremiah 44:28 • Jeremiah 1:12 • Isaiah 40:8

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
A God Who Rises Early to Plead	Jeremiah 44:4 • Matthew 23:37 • Mark 12:2-6
Sin as Self-Destruction	Jeremiah 44:7 • John 8:34 • Romans 6:23
Given Over to What They Insisted On	Jeremiah 44:25 • Psalm 81:11-12 • Romans 1:24-25
The Name No Longer Named	Jeremiah 44:26 • Acts 4:12 • Philippians 2:9-11
Only a Remnant Escaping	Jeremiah 44:14 • Isaiah 10:22 • Romans 9:27
His Word Stands Forever	Jeremiah 44:28 • Matthew 24:35 • 1 Peter 1:24-25
Worship at the Kitchen Table	Jeremiah 44:19 • Matthew 6:24 • Colossians 3:5

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - Jeremiah 44 Commentary (David Guzik) - the last sermon in Egypt, the queen of heaven, and the sign of Pharaoh Hophra
- United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 44 - the Egyptian Jewish colonies and the fate of the refugee community after Jeremiah

- Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 44 - exposition of the congregation's refusal and the oath sworn by Yahweh's great name

Jeremiah 44 - Opening Intro

This is the last sermon of Jeremiah's life that Scripture records, and it is the only one where the congregation answers back out loud. Nowhere else in the prophets does a whole assembly stand up and reply. What they say is: no.

Read verse 17 slowly, because it is one of the most honest arguments any idolater ever made, and it is entirely built out of data. When we burned incense to the queen of the sky, we had plenty of food, we were well, and we saw no evil. Since we stopped, we have lacked everything and been eaten by sword and famine. That is not superstition. That is a chart. They lived through Josiah's reform and then through the collapse, and they drew the obvious line between the two.

And they got it exactly backwards. The reform was the last mercy before a judgment that generations had already earned; the disasters that followed were the bill arriving, not the penalty for cleaning house. But you can see how it looked from inside. Correlation is a terrible pastor, and a whole nation ordered its worship around it.

The queen of the sky is Ishtar - Astarte - and the detail worth noticing is how homely her cult was. Cakes pressed in a mold with her face on them. Drink poured out at the door. This was not a state religion imposed from a palace; it was a family practice, run out of the kitchen, taught by mothers to daughters. Chapter 7 already showed us the whole household at it: children gathering wood, fathers lighting the fire, women kneading the dough. The most durable idolatry is almost always the domestic kind.

The women's reply in verse 19 deserves respect even in its defiance, because it is true. Did we make her cakes without our husbands? No. They did not. The men had known, and approved, and eaten. When Jeremiah answers he does not accept the division at all - he addresses the men, the women, and all the people together. There is no innocent party in the room.

Then comes verse 25, and God stops arguing. "Establish then your vows, and perform your vows." Go ahead. Do it. It is the sound of a door being left open on purpose, and it is far more frightening than any threat in the chapter. There is a judgment that consists simply of being permitted.

And the sentence in verse 26 has no parallel anywhere: My name will no longer be named in the mouth of any man of Judah in all the land of Egypt. They had used the phrase "as the Lord Yahweh lives" as a formality while serving another god - a signature on documents, a habit of speech. So the signature is revoked. The judgment is not that He shouts at them. It is that the sound of His name goes out of their mouths.

Before we read, listen for the question in verse 28, because it is the question the entire book has been asking: whose word will stand, mine or theirs? Everything else - the kings, the sieges, the false prophets, the burned scroll, the cistern - has been a long argument about that one sentence. And it is still the only question that matters about anything we are currently sure of.

Jeremiah 44:1-30 (WEB)

1 The word that came to Jeremiah concerning all the Jews who lived in the land of Egypt, who lived at Migdol, and at Tahpanhes, and at Memphis, and in the country of Pathros, saying,

2 "Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: 'You have seen all the evil that I have brought on Jerusalem, and on all the cities of Judah. Behold, today they are a desolation, and no man dwells in them,

3 because of their wickedness which they have committed to provoke me to anger, in that they went to burn incense, to serve other gods that they didn't know, neither they, nor you, nor your fathers.

4 However I sent to you all my servants the prophets, rising up early and sending them, saying, "Oh, don't do this abominable thing that I hate."[13,14]

5 But they didn't listen and didn't incline their ear. They didn't turn from their wickedness, to stop burning incense to other gods.

6 Therefore my wrath and my anger was poured out, and was kindled in the cities of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem; and they are wasted and desolate, as it is today.'

7 "Therefore now Yahweh, the God of Armies, the God of Israel, says: 'Why do you commit great evil against your own souls, to cut off from yourselves man and woman, infant and nursing child out of the middle of Judah, to leave yourselves no one remaining;[15,16]

8 in that you provoke me to anger with the works of your hands, burning incense to other gods in the land of Egypt, where you have gone to live; that you may be cut off, and that you may be a curse and a reproach among all the nations of the earth?

9 Have you forgotten the wickedness of your fathers, and the wickedness of the kings of Judah, and the wickedness of their wives, and your own wickedness, and the wickedness of your wives, which they committed in the land of Judah and in the streets of Jerusalem?

10 They are not humbled even to this day, neither have they feared, nor walked in my law, nor in my statutes, that I set before you and before your fathers.'

11 "Therefore Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says: 'Behold, I will set my face against you for evil, even to cut off all Judah.

---

[13] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 7:25 • 2 Chronicles 36:15-16 - *servants the prophets sent daily, rising up early, mocked until there was no remedy*

[14] **Messianic Connection:** Matthew 23:37 • Mark 12:2-6 - *how often would I have gathered you, and a landowner still sending servants*

[15] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 7:19 • Proverbs 8:36 - *do they provoke me, or themselves to their own confusion - all who hate me love death*

[16] **Messianic Connection:** John 8:34 • Romans 6:23 - *everyone who sins is a bondservant of sin, and the wages of sin is death*

12 I will take the remnant of Judah, that have set their faces to go into the land of Egypt to live there, and they will all be consumed. They will fall in the land of Egypt. They will be consumed by the sword and by the famine. They will die, from the least even to the greatest, by the sword and by the famine. They will be an object of horror, an astonishment, and a curse, and a reproach.

13 For I will punish those who dwell in the land of Egypt, as I have punished Jerusalem, by the sword, by the famine, and by the pestilence;

14 so that none of the remnant of Judah, who have gone into the land of Egypt to live there, will escape or be left to return into the land of Judah, to which they have a desire to return to dwell there; for no one will return except those who will escape.'"[17]

15 Then all the men who knew that their wives burned incense to other gods, and all the women who stood by, a great assembly, even all the people who lived in the land of Egypt, in Pathros, answered Jeremiah, saying,

16 "As for the word that you have spoken to us in Yahweh's name, we will not listen to you.[18]

17 But we will certainly perform every word that has gone out of our mouth, to burn incense to the queen of the sky, and to pour out drink offerings to her, as we have done, we and our fathers, our kings and our princes, in the cities of Judah, and in the streets of Jerusalem; for then had we plenty of food, and were well, and saw no evil.[19]

18 But since we stopped burning incense to the queen of the sky, and pouring out drink offerings to her, we have lacked all things, and have been consumed by the sword and by the famine.[20]

19 "When we burned incense to the queen of the sky, and poured out drink offerings to her, did we make her cakes to worship her, and pour out drink offerings to her, without our husbands?"

20 Then Jeremiah said to all the people, to the men, and to the women, even to all the people who had given him an answer, saying,

21 "The incense that you burned in the cities of Judah, and in the streets of Jerusalem, you and your fathers, your kings and your princes, and the people of the land, didn't Yahweh remember them, and didn't it come into his mind?

22 Thus Yahweh could no longer bear it, because of the evil of your doings, and because of the abominations which you have committed. Therefore your land has become a desolation, and an astonishment, and a curse, without inhabitant, as it is today.

---

[17] **Messianic Connection:** Isaiah 10:22 • Romans 9:27 - *though the number be as the sand of the sea, only a remnant will return*

[18] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 6:16-17 • Isaiah 30:9 - *we will not walk in it, we will not listen - rebellious children unwilling to hear the law*

[19] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 7:18 • 2 Kings 23:5 - *the whole household baking cakes for the queen of the sky, and the priests Josiah removed*

[20] **Cross-Reference:** Hosea 2:5-8 • Deuteronomy 8:17-18 - *crediting the lovers for the grain and oil that Yahweh Himself had given*

23 Because you have burned incense, and because you have sinned against Yahweh, and have not obeyed Yahweh's voice, nor walked in his law, nor in his statutes, nor in his testimonies; therefore this evil has happened to you, as it is today."

24 Moreover Jeremiah said to all the people, including all the women, "Hear Yahweh's word, all Judah who are in the land of Egypt!

25 Yahweh of Armies, the God of Israel, says, 'You and your wives have both spoken with your mouths, and with your hands have fulfilled it, saying, "We will surely perform our vows that we have vowed, to burn incense to the queen of the sky, and to pour out drink offerings to her." "'Establish then your vows, and perform your vows.'[21,22]

26 "Therefore hear Yahweh's word, all Judah who dwell in the land of Egypt: 'Behold, I have sworn by my great name,' says Yahweh, 'that my name will no more be named in the mouth of any man of Judah in all the land of Egypt, saying, "As the Lord Yahweh lives."[23]

27 Behold, I watch over them for evil, and not for good; and all the men of Judah who are in the land of Egypt will be consumed by the sword and by the famine, until they are all gone.[24]

28 Those who escape the sword will return out of the land of Egypt into the land of Judah few in number. All the remnant of Judah, who have gone into the land of Egypt to live there, will know whose word will stand, mine or theirs.[25]

29 "'This will be the sign to you,' says Yahweh, 'that I will punish you in this place, that you may know that my words will surely stand against you for evil.'

30 Yahweh says, 'Behold, I will give Pharaoh Hophra king of Egypt into the hand of his enemies, and into the hand of those who seek his life; as I gave Zedekiah king of Judah into the hand of Nebuchadnezzar king of Babylon, who was his enemy, and sought his life.'"[26]

---

[21] **Cross-Reference:** Numbers 30:2 • Ecclesiastes 5:4-5 - *a vow binds the soul, and better not to vow than to vow and not pay*

[22] **Messianic Connection:** Psalm 81:11-12 • Romans 1:24-25 - *so I gave them up to their own hearts' lust - judgment that consists of being permitted*

[23] **Messianic Connection:** Acts 4:12 • Philippians 2:9-11 - *a name withdrawn from one mouth, and the name given above every name*

[24] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 1:12 • Jeremiah 31:28 - *the watching branch - I watch over my word to perform it, to break down and to build*

[25] **Messianic Connection:** Matthew 24:35 • 1 Peter 1:24-25 - *heaven and earth pass away, but His words do not - the word of the Lord endures forever*

[26] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 46:25-26 • Ezekiel 29:2-3 - *Pharaoh and those who trust in him handed over, and the great monster of the Nile*

CHAPTER 45 - A Word for Baruch

Key Notes

- The oracle is dated to the fourth year of Jehoiakim - about 605 BC, some twenty years before the events of chapters 43 and 44 (Jeremiah 45:1).
- Its placement here is deliberate. It closes the scroll the way a scribe signs his own work at the end of the manuscript (Jeremiah 45:1).
- That fourth year is the year of chapter 36 - the scroll Baruch wrote, read aloud in the temple, and watched the king cut up and burn (Jeremiah 45:1).
- Baruch is a man of standing. His brother Seraiah was Zedekiah's quartermaster, and a clay seal bearing his own name has been recovered - he had a career to lose (Jeremiah 45:2).
- Verse 3 preserves the only words of Baruch recorded in Scripture, and they are a complaint: "Woe is me now!" (Jeremiah 45:3).
- God quotes the complaint back to him verbatim before answering it. He had heard it exactly as it was said (Jeremiah 45:3).
- "Yahweh has added sorrow to my pain" - Baruch does not blame circumstances or enemies. He says the grief came from God, and God does not correct him (Jeremiah 45:3).
- The answer begins not with Baruch's trouble but with God's: what I built I am breaking down, what I planted I am plucking up (Jeremiah 45:4).
- Those are the verbs of Jeremiah 1:10, and the demolition costs the Builder something. Baruch is being told his sorrow is a share in a larger one (Jeremiah 45:4).
- "Do you seek great things for yourself? Don't seek them" is the only rebuke in the oracle, and it is a question rather than a verdict (Jeremiah 45:5).
- The timing matters: greatness is not being called sinful, it is being called unavailable. This is not the era for it (Jeremiah 45:5).
- The promise given is deliberately small and completely sufficient - "I will let you escape with your life wherever you go" (Jeremiah 45:5).
- Life as spoil is this book's particular mercy, given to Ebed-Melech and to those who surrendered, and now to a scribe (Jeremiah 45:5).
- "Wherever you go" is quietly generous, and it holds even in Egypt - which is where he ends up, carried off in chapter 43 (Jeremiah 45:5).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
The Scroll of Jehoiakim's Fourth Year	Jeremiah 45:1 • Jeremiah 36:1-4 • Jeremiah 25:1
Baruch the Son of Neriah	Jeremiah 45:2 • Jeremiah 32:12-13 • Jeremiah 36:26

Topic	References
“Woe Is Me”	Jeremiah 45:3 • Jeremiah 15:10 • Psalm 120:5
Weary With Groaning, Finding No Rest	Jeremiah 45:3 • Psalm 6:6 • Lamentations 5:5
Building and Planting, Run in Reverse	Jeremiah 45:4 • Jeremiah 1:10 • Jeremiah 31:28
“Don’t Seek Great Things for Yourself”	Jeremiah 45:5 • Psalm 131:1 • Proverbs 23:4-5
Your Life as Your Spoil	Jeremiah 45:5 • Jeremiah 39:18 • Jeremiah 21:9
Evil on All Flesh	Jeremiah 45:5 • Jeremiah 25:31 • Isaiah 66:16

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Heard Before He Repeats Himself	Jeremiah 45:3 • Matthew 6:8 • Hebrews 4:15
Rest for the Weary	Jeremiah 45:3 • Matthew 11:28-30 • Hebrews 4:9-10
A Builder Grieved by His Own Demolition	Jeremiah 45:4 • Lamentations 3:33 • Luke 19:41
Not Seeking Greatness	Jeremiah 45:5 • Mark 10:43-45 • John 5:41
Life Itself as the Reward	Jeremiah 45:5 • John 12:25 • Revelation 2:10
The Servant Behind the Scenes	Jeremiah 45:1 • Romans 16:22 • Hebrews 6:10

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - Jeremiah 45 Commentary (David Guzik) - the personal oracle to Baruch, its date, and the promise of life as spoil
- United Church of God - Beyond Today Bible Commentary, Jeremiah 45 - Baruch’s role as scribe and the chapter’s placement at the close of the scroll
- Verse By Verse Ministry International - Jeremiah, Lesson 45 - exposition of ambition surrendered in a generation of judgment

Jeremiah 45 - Opening Intro

Five verses, and they are for one man.

Baruch has been in this book since chapter 32, and he is almost always described by his function: the son of Neriah, who wrote at the mouth of Jeremiah. He buys the field deed and seals it. He takes dictation. He reads the scroll aloud in the temple when Jeremiah cannot go himself, and then hides while Jehoiakim slices it column by column into the brazier. In chapter 43 he is accused of running the prophet. In chapter 43 he is also carried into Egypt with him. He is the person in the room whose name is on nothing.

This is a man with prospects, too. His brother Seraiah served in Zedekiah's court, and archaeologists have recovered a clay bulla stamped "belonging to Berechiah son of Neriah the scribe." He came from the class that produced officials. Instead he spent his working life taking down the words of the most hated man in Jerusalem.

So in the fourth year of Jehoiakim, with his scroll in ashes and a warrant out for both of them, he says the one thing Scripture preserves from his mouth: "Woe is me now! For Yahweh has added sorrow to my pain! I am weary with my groaning, and I find no rest."

Notice three things about the answer he gets. First, God repeats his complaint back to him word for word before responding to it. Baruch had probably said it to himself, or to Jeremiah, on a bad night. It had been heard, precisely, and it is quoted with no mockery in it.

Second, the answer does not begin with Baruch. It begins with God: what I have built, I am breaking down; what I have planted, I am plucking up. Those are the verbs from Jeremiah's commission, and here they are turned on the Builder's own work. Before God says anything about Baruch's grief, He says: this is costing me too. Your sorrow is not being dismissed. It is being placed inside a larger one.

Third, the correction is a question, not a sentence. "Do you seek great things for yourself? Don't seek them." It is not that ambition is wicked. It is that this is not the season for it, and a man who keeps reaching for a career in a generation like this one will break his hands on it. The word for what he is offered instead is spoil - plunder, what a soldier walks off the field carrying. In a year when everything is being taken, your life will be the thing you get to keep.

It is a small promise. Read it in a comfortable century and it can sound like a consolation prize. Read it in 586, standing over the ruins with the temple still smoking, and it is enormous. And it comes with the phrase that must have mattered most twenty years later, when he was dragged across the Egyptian border by men who blamed him for the whole thing: "wherever you go."

Before we read, take the smallness of this seriously. The God who was in the middle of dismantling a nation stopped, in the fourth year of Jehoiakim, to answer one exhausted man who had not asked for anything except to be allowed to feel it. He never told him the pain was unwarranted. He told him it was shared, and that he would come out of it alive.

Jeremiah 45:1-5 (WEB)

1 The message that Jeremiah the prophet spoke to Baruch the son of Neriah, when he wrote these words in a book at the mouth of Jeremiah, in the fourth year of Jehoiakim the son of Josiah, king of Judah, saying,[27,28]

2 "Yahweh, the God of Israel, says to you, Baruch:

---

[27] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 36:1-4 • Jeremiah 25:1 - *the fourth year of Jehoiakim - the year of the scroll, and of Nebuchadnezzar's first year*

[28] **Messianic Connection:** Romans 16:22 • Hebrews 6:10 - *Tertius who wrote the epistle, and a God not unrighteous to forget your work*

3 ‘You said, “Woe is me now! For Yahweh has added sorrow to my pain! I am weary with my groaning, and I find no rest.”’[29,30]

4 “You shall tell him, Yahweh says: ‘Behold, that which I have built, I will break down, and that which I have planted I will pluck up; and this in the whole land.[31,32]

5 Do you seek great things for yourself? Don’t seek them; for, behold, I will bring evil on all flesh,’ says Yahweh; ‘but I will let you escape with your life wherever you go.’”[33,34,35]

---

[29] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 15:10 • Psalm 6:6 - *woe is me, my mother, that you bore me - and a bed soaked with weeping*

[30] **Messianic Connection:** Matthew 6:8 • Hebrews 4:15 - *your Father knows what you need before you ask, and a High Priest who feels our weakness*

[31] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 1:10 • Jeremiah 31:28 - *to pluck up and to break down, to build and to plant - the commission verbs, reversed*

[32] **Messianic Connection:** Lamentations 3:33 • Luke 19:41 - *He does not afflict willingly, and He wept over the city as He said what must come*

[33] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 131:1 • Proverbs 23:4-5 - *I do not concern myself with great matters, and riches that sprout wings and fly away*

[34] **Cross-Reference:** Jeremiah 39:18 • Jeremiah 21:9 - *your life will be your spoil - the same mercy given to Ebed-Melech and to those who yielded*

[35] **Messianic Connection:** Mark 10:43-45 • John 12:25 - *whoever wants to be great must serve, and whoever loses his life keeps it*

Major Themes Across Jeremiah 43-45

- Denying the commission when the message cannot be answered - “Yahweh has not sent you”
- Blaming the scribe: how a word gets dismissed by finding someone to blame for it
- Fear rewriting a promise into a threat, and then arguing with its own version
- A homecoming undone by the people who survived to enjoy it
- God still speaking on the wrong side of a border - disobedience changes the address, not the relationship
- Prophecy done with the hands: stones in wet mortar at a foreign king’s door
- Empires as instruments - “Nebuchadnezzar my servant” - and the gods of Egypt worn like a coat
- Idolatry as self-harm: great evil committed against our own souls
- Correlation mistaken for covenant, and a nation’s worship ordered around the years that went well
- The domestic idol, taught in kitchens and passed down, harder to remove than any state religion
- Being handed over to what we insisted on - “perform your vows” as a sentence, not a permission
- A name withdrawn from the mouth that used it as a formality
- The one question underneath the whole book: whose word will stand, mine or theirs
- A tired servant heard by name, his complaint quoted back without mockery
- Ambition set down for a season, and life itself received as spoil

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May we never call a word false simply because it asks us to stay somewhere hard.

May we stop looking for the Baruch in the room - the influence, the agenda, the handler - when what we have actually been handed is the word of God.

May we hear what He said, and not the frightened version of it we composed on the way home.

May He keep us from crossing borders He did not open, and if we have already crossed one, may we remember that He has followed us there and is still speaking.

May we be honest about the years we credit to the wrong god, and brave enough to keep obeying through the seasons that look like they are costing us.

May the idols we inherited in our own kitchens be named and put down in our generation, so that our children are not taught them by our hands.

May He never say to us, perform your vows - and may we never be so certain that He stops arguing with us.

May His name stay in our mouths, and mean what it says when it is there.

And for those of us who are tired tonight, who have carried someone else's work and found no rest in it - may we hear Him quote our own complaint back to us gently, and promise us our lives wherever we go.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.